2.5 Military Applications of First-generation Drones

The first generation of drones was developed primarily for military purposes, marking the earliest use of unmanned systems in defense operations. These drones emerged during the early to mid-20th century, a period when nations sought safer and more efficient methods for training, reconnaissance, and target simulation. Although limited in technological sophistication, first-generation drones provided an invaluable foundation for future military UAV programs by demonstrating the strategic potential of pilotless flight in combat and support roles. Table 2.3 summarizes the major military applications of first-generation drones, illustrating their early use in training, reconnaissance, combat experimentation, and technological research. These early UAVs were primarily developed to improve defense readiness and gunnery precision, reduce pilot risk, and explore the possibilities of pilotless aerial operations (Mayer, 2015).